

lesson, Mom stays in the car and makes sales calls on her cellular car phone. The lesson over, Mom drives Monica to the Glendale mall. Monica plans to meet a friend there and shop for a black dress for her upcoming violin recital.

Mom arrives home and puts away the groceries. She notes that the refrigerator has been cleaned out of edibles, a sure sign that Alex and maybe a few of his friends have passed through the kitchen. She calls Alex at the Superscoop to tell him about the appointment with his high-school counselor. Alex says fine, he'll be there, but please don't bother him about such triviality while he's working.

Mom updates the shopping list on the computer, makes more phone calls, and heads off to call on a young professional couple. Most of her clients, it seems, are young professionals who can see her only between 7:00 and 10:00 P.M.

Dad gets home as Mom backs out of the garage. They honk greetings at each other. Dad fixes himself a scotch, tunes in Dan Rather on TV, and peeks in the freezer. The freezer has more gourmet dinners than the menu at Chasen's. He chooses beef Stroganoff with rice and a spinach soufflé, and sticks both in the microwave. He used to like to cook. Now he wonders how he ever managed to prepare something to eat before they had a microwave.

He leaves the Stroganoff and spinach-soufflé box tops in a basket by the computer so Mom can update the grocery list. Mom's inventory system, he figures, has better controls than most Pasadena retail outlets.

Dad wolfs down his gourmet dinner in front of the TV. Even so, he arrives late to his school-board meeting. He volunteers to chair the fund-raising committee this year.

Mom gets home at 9:30 P.M., excited with her success. She sold \$300,000 of life insurance. To celebrate, she makes herself a weak wine spritzer. She zaps a diet-delight frozen dinner and goes to the TV room to be near Dad while she eats. Dad is watching a well-worn video copy of *Caddy Shack* and trying to catch up on business reading during